

ApplyDirect SA — How to Run Everything

Complete setup guide for the **Subscription site** and the **Admin panel**.

One-click start, database setup, user accounts, and the admin area — all covered.

Cape Town, South Africa

What is in this package?

This folder contains four mini-apps (called **sections**). Each one is self-contained — backend + frontend:

Section	What it does	Port
sections/subscription/backend	API for sign-up, login, payment plans, orders & payments	3002
sections/subscription/frontend	The student website (home, plans, checkout)	3004
sections/admin/backend	API for admin login, students, plans, orders	3003
sections/admin/frontend	The admin panel (dashboard, approve students)	3005

All four share one MySQL database named `uniapply` on **port 3307**.

Option 1 — One-Click Start (easiest)

Double-click `START-ALL.bat` in this folder. That's it.

The script automatically:

- Checks if MySQL (XAMPP/MariaDB) is running on port 3307 and starts it if needed.
- Installs any missing npm dependencies (first run only — needs internet).
- Sets up the database and demo accounts (safe — never deletes existing data).
- Starts all 4 servers in minimised windows.
- Opens your browser on the student site and the admin panel.

Heads up: this project uses the built-in XAMPP MySQL (MariaDB) on **port 3307** with a blank root password. A separate MySQL install on port 3306 (for example MySQL80) is not used by this project, so its settings don't apply here.

Option 2 — Manual start (Command by Command)

If you prefer to run each piece yourself:

1. Start MySQL (XAMPP) on port 3307

Make sure MySQL is listening on **3307**. From a terminal:

```
netstat -an | find ":3307"
```

If nothing shows, start MariaDB manually:

```
"C:\xampp\mysql\bin\mysqld.exe" --port=3307 --basedir=C:\xampp\mysql --datadir=C:\xampp\mysql\data
```

2. Set up the database

Each backend has a `setup.js` that creates tables and demo accounts. Run both:

```
cd sections\subscription\backend
npm run db:setup

cd ../../admin/backend
npm run db:setup
```

3. Start the two backends

```
cd sections\subscription\backend
npm run dev          # API on http://localhost:3002

cd ../../admin/backend
npm run dev          # API on http://localhost:3003
```

4. Start the two frontends

```
cd sections\subscription\frontend
npm run dev          # Student site on http://localhost:3004

cd ../../admin/frontend
npm run dev          # Admin panel on http://localhost:3005
```

5. Open in the browser

```
http://localhost:3004    Student site (Sign up, Log in, Plans, Checkout)
http://localhost:3005    Admin panel (Log in, Dashboard)
```

Demo accounts (already in the database)

Account	Email	Password	Role
Student 1	thabo@email.com	password123	Student (approved)
Student 2	zanele@email.com	password123	Student (approved)
Admin	admin@uniapply.co.za	admin123	Admin

How the student flow works

Sign up on `http://localhost:3004/register` — the new account starts as *Pending*.

The school admin clicks **Admin Login** in the footer of the student site (goes to `http://localhost:3005`).

Admin signs in with `admin@uniapply.co.za / admin123` and approves the new student.

The student logs in on the student site, picks a plan on the **Payment Plans** page, and checks out (card / EFT / Instant EFT are simulated).

The paid order appears in the Admin panel under **Orders**.

Card (test) details for checkout

Field	Use this test value
Card number	4242 4242 4242 4242
Cardholder name	Any name
Expiry	Any future date, e.g. 12/27
CVV	Any 3 digits, e.g. 123

Screens & their web addresses

Screen	Address
Home page (student)	<code>http://localhost:3004/</code>
Sign up	<code>http://localhost:3004/register</code>
Log in (student)	<code>http://localhost:3004/login</code>
Payment plans	<code>http://localhost:3004/payment-plan</code>
Checkout / payment	<code>http://localhost:3004/payment</code>
Admin login	<code>http://localhost:3005/</code>

Stopping the app

Double-click `STOP-ALL.bat` in this folder. It closes the four servers. (MySQL on 3307 is left running — stop it from XAMPP if you like.)

Troubleshooting

- **"MySQL connection failed"** — MySQL isn't running on port 3307. Run `START-ALL.bat` again or start XAMPP MariaDB manually (see above).
- **"Access denied for user 'root'"** — your MySQL has a root password. In `sections/*/backend/.env` change `DB_PASSWORD=` to your real password (XAMPP default is blank).
- **Port already in use** — close the old minimised server windows, or stop them with `STOP-ALL.bat`, then start again.
- **Page won't open** — wait a few seconds after starting; Vite (the frontends) needs time to boot.
- **First run is slow** — `npm install` downloads dependencies; only happens once and needs internet.